Project Title:

From Helpful Reminder to Digital Manipulation: Exploring Conversational Digital Nudges in AI-Mediated Institutional Communication

Background & Rationale:

Conversational AI has transformed how organizations interact with customers through messaging platforms such as WhatsApp, Telegram, and mobile chat interfaces. Unlike traditional websites or mobile applications, conversational interfaces operate within socially intimate communication environments where interactions closely resemble interpersonal conversations. Organizations increasingly employ conversational digital nudges, including reminders, anthropomorphic language, conversational re-engagement prompts, and emotionally framed messages to encourage continued interaction and service usage.

While digital nudges have demonstrated positive outcomes such as improved engagement, service adoption, and decision support, emerging evidence suggests that these same conversational strategies may blur the boundary between helpful assistance and subtle behavioral manipulation. Particularly in high-trust domains such as banking, insurance, healthcare, and government services, conversational AI systems may appropriate interpersonal communication norms to influence user behaviour, raising important questions regarding autonomy, perceived manipulation, trust, and ethical AI design.

Despite growing research on digital nudging, chatbot anthropomorphism, and persuasive technologies, limited work has examined how conversational AI leverages interpersonal conversational norms within institutional contexts and how users perceive the transition from beneficial guidance to manipulative persuasion. This study seeks to address this gap.

Objectives:

- To identify and classify conversational digital nudge strategies employed by organizations across AI-enabled messaging platforms.
- To develop a taxonomy of conversational digital nudges used in institutional communication.
- To examine how different conversational nudge strategies influence user engagement, trust, perceived warmth, perceived manipulation, and autonomy.
- To identify conditions under which conversational digital nudges transition from being perceived as helpful to being perceived as manipulative.
- To propose design principles for responsible conversational AI in institutional settings.

Methodology:

- Study design: Exploratory Sequential Mixed Methods (QUAL → Experiment)
- Sample: 200 - 300 consumers (aged 25–35) recruited via online panel
- Analysis: Qual Study: Thematic Analysis / Gioia Methodology

Quant study: ANOVA/MANOVA and/or Structural equation modeling (SEM) to test hypotheses; mediation analysis (if we find any variable)

Deliverables:

- Mid-term report with literature review and data-collection plan (by end of Month 2)
- Final written report (8,000–10,000 words) presenting results, discussion, and managerial implications (by Month 6)
- PowerPoint presentation for departmental/panel seminar (in December 2026)

Proposed Timeline:

- July–August: Literature review; instrument design (IRB clearance (if required); questionnaire ready)
- September: Pilot testing; questionnaire refinement (Pilot report)
- October: Data collection (Raw data secured)
- November: Data analysis; interpretation of results (Draft findings report)
- Early December: Final write-up; presentation preparation (Full report & slides completed)

Supervision & Resources:

- Faculty Advisors: Dr. Mukesh Narmetta (MIS) & Dr. Sandhya Banda (Marketing)
- Meetings: Bi-weekly progress review
- Resources: Access to the university's survey tools, statistical software (e.g., SPSS/AMOS), and library databases